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Members belonging to voluntary agencies, who were the backbone of the community participative reforms, were soon at their wit's end wondering how to continue with their work with the inmates that they had been committed to and had set time limits on. Prison headquarters maintained that such members had not been restricted from doing their work. However, the warders of the different jails that these volunteers visited insisted that all permissions for them to enter the jail had been withdrawn in practice. They further insisted that if they wanted any interaction with the inmates then it should take place only in the visitors' galleries. These volunteers reported that they were made to wait for, at times, even more than two hours before the warders decided that they could enter for a brief period. These volunteers started forming the distinct impression that things were being made very difficult for them so that they may be dissuaded on their own and the warders could claim that the good work stopped because of lack of interest on the volunteers' part and not because of any express orders from them (i.e., the warders).

A group that interacted with the women inmates was obviously pained to report that the latter had already been told by their assistant warder, who was directly in charge of them, that their days of 'breathing fresh air' were now over and that they would have to breathe the air that would be allowed only by her. The same warder had earlier, when Kiran was at the helm of affairs, shown deep concern for the condition of the unfortunate women inmates. She had claimed that nothing better could have happened for these unfortunates than the taking over of the charge of the jail by Kiran Bedi. The hypocrisy of such staff members was a painful awareness of the plight of the inmates in the re-emergence of the old and sordid realities of the jail.

The price of a bundle of *beedis* soon fell to Rs 50 from Rs 150. Obviously, access to them had become easier. The inmates were no longer allowed to visit the supermarket that had been set up for them and which was run by them along with the jail staff. Money accruing from the sales went partly to the inmates who ran the supermarket. Items soon began to be purchased and given to the inmates by the staff at exorbitant rates and the poorer lot was denied this facility. Money had to shelled out even for *mulaqaats*. Patients sent out on referrals were taken around in the police van and only allowed into the hospitals when the requisite money had been handed over. One diabetic prisoner complained that although the outside medical report showed that his blood sugar count had soared to as high as 385 the jail hospital report mentioned it to be only 125, which was normal. The inmate was poor and claimed that such manipulation had been done because he did not have any money to give to the doctor–warder nexus that soon started functioning quite effectively.

One researcher who somehow managed to be patient enough to go into the jail after long hours of waiting reported that she was an eyewitness to a number of beatings inflicted by long-term prisoners on inmates who had not even spent a day in prison as yet. This, she affirmed, was being done in the presence of the jail staff. When she approached them on one such occasion she was told that the inmates knew what they were doing and that they had their own system of sorting out such things. She was quite shocked to see such blatant irresponsibility on the part of the staff on whom the well-being of the inmates depended. Obviously, the old mindset had very smoothly slipped back into place where the only onus that the jail authorities at the lower level were willing to bear was that of beatings and punishments. They started reiterating their old statements that all inmates who came to Tihar Jail were criminals and their time there should be made as uncomfortable as possible.

The prison garbage dump started stinking once again. Prisoners who had been so willing to work on the 'garbage-into-manure' project that had begun earning considerable amounts of money for the prisoners' welfare fund stopped doing so. They explained to the volunteers and social activists that